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The Revolt of 1857

Pre-1857 Uprisings

- Indian resentment manifested through various uprisings before 1857, including **religio-political violence**, **tribal movements**, **peasant rebellions**, and **agrarian riots**.
- Notable incidents: **Vellore Mutiny (1806)**, **Barrackpore Mutiny (1824)**, **Bareilly Rising (1816)**, **Kol Insurrection (1831-32)**, and **Santhal Rising (1855-56)**.

Note: A detailed account of all such uprisings and movements will be covered in a separate chapter, “**People’s Resistance Against the British**,” later.

THE BEGINNING: CARTRIDGE CONTROVERSY

- Cartridge Issue:** The introduction of **Enfield rifles**, with cartridges allegedly greased with beef and pig fat, angered both **Hindu** and **Muslim** sepoys.
- Earlier signs of discontent:**
 - Berhampur (Feb 1857):** 19th Native Infantry refused to use the rifle, leading to disbandment.
 - Barrackpore (April 1857):** **Mangal Pande** fired at his sergeant major, was executed, and his regiment disbanded.
 - Meerut (May 9, 1857):** 85 men of the 3rd Native Cavalry, imprisoned for refusing cartridges, sparked the rebellion by mutinying the next day.

Bahadur Shah Zafar as Leader

- Rebels declared **Bahadur Shah Zafar** the symbolic **Emperor of India**, making **Delhi** the revolt’s centre. He called for a united Indian front against the British.

Spread, Centres & Leaders of the Revolt

Places of Revolt	Indian Leaders	British Officials who Suppressed the Revolt
Delhi	Bahadur Shah II and General Bakht Khan	John Nicholson, Lieutenant Willoughby, Lieutenant Hudson
Lucknow	Begum Hazrat Mahal and her son Birjis Qadir, Ahmadullah	Henry Lawrence, Brigadier Inglis, Henry Havelock, James Outram, Sir Colin Campbell
Kanpur	Nana Saheb, Rao Sahib, Tantia Tope and Azimullah Khan	Sir Colin Campbell, Sir Hugh Wheeler
Bareilly	Khan Bahadur Khan	Sir Colin Campbell
Jhansi	Lakshmi Bai	General Hugh Rose
Gwalior	Tantia Tope	General Hugh Rose
Ahmedabad & Banaras	Maulvi Liaqat Ali	Colonel James Neil
Bihar	Kunwar Singh and Amar Singh	William Taylor

1857 REVOLT: MAJOR CAUSES

- Economic Causes:**
 - Peasantry** - heavy taxes, debt, eviction, poverty;
 - artisans** - loss of patronage, decline of handicrafts;
 - trade & industry** - high tariffs, collapsed exports;
 - zamindars** - loss of estates (especially in **Awadh**).
- Political Causes:**
 - Subsidiary Alliance** (1798),
 - Doctrine of Lapse** (1848),
 - Effective Control** weakened native rulers;
 - Mughals** - humiliation;
 - Pax Britannica** - disbanded military groups.
- Administrative Causes:**
 - Corruption** - police, courts, revenue;
 - Alien rule; aristocracy** - denied high posts.
- Socio-Religious Causes:**
 - Reforms** - Sati Abolition (1829), widow remarriage (1856);
 - Missionary activities; cultural insensitivity** - bone dust in flour, beef/pig fat cartridges.
- Sepoy Discontent:**
 - General Service Enlistment Act (1856)** - caste violations;
 - Racial discrimination**, lower pay; loss of **Awadh** (1856).
- External Influences:**
 - Defeats - **Afghan War (1838-42)**,
 - Punjab Wars (1845-49)**, **Crimean War (1854-56)** undermined British invincibility.

Civilian Participation

- The revolt saw widespread civilian involvement, particularly in **Awadh** and **North-Western Provinces**.
- Civilians targeted **moneylenders**, **zamindars**, and British institutions, destroying financial records, reflecting deep social grievances.
- In **Awadh**, over **100,000 civilians** died, emphasising the scale of the uprising.
- The rebellion witnessed **Hindu-Muslim cooperation**, with nationalistic imagery used to rally against the British.

Suppression of the Revolt

- **Delhi** fell to the British on **September 20, 1857**, marking a significant blow to the revolt. **Bahadur**
- **Bahadur Shah** was exiled, and royal princes were executed. Key British commanders, such as **Sir Colin Campbell** (Kanpur), **Sir Hugh Rose** (Jhansi), and **Colonel Neill** (Benaras), played pivotal roles in suppressing the revolt.
- By **1859**, **Nana Saheb** escaped to Nepal, while **Tantia Tope** was captured and executed.
- Key leaders like **Kunwar Singh**, **Bakht Khan**, and **Khan Bahadur Khan** died, and the **Begum of Awadh** sought refuge in Nepal.
- The British imposed **martial law** in North India, with ordinary Britishers empowered to punish suspected rebels.

Causes of 1857 Revolt Failure

- **Limited Spread:** Focused on **Western Bihar**, **Oudh**, **Rohilkhand**; excluded **Bombay** and **Madras**.
- **Lack of Participation:** **Zamindars**, **middle class**, and **rulers** remained loyal for economic reasons.
- **Weapon Disparity:** **Indian sepoys** with traditional weapons vs. **British** with **Enfield rifles**.
- **Leadership Failure:** No **central leadership** or coordination among rebel leaders.
- **No Unified Ideology:** Varied grievances hindered unity.
- **British Advantages:** **Superior resources**, **electric telegraph**, and prior suppression experience.

Consequences of the Revolt of 1857

- **Act for Better Government of India, 1858**
 - **Abolition of Company Rule:** British Crown took direct control.
 - **Sovereignty Declared:** Queen Victoria became sovereign of British India.
 - **Secretary of State:** Appointed to manage India directly.
- **Queen's Proclamation of 1858**
 - **Title Change:** Lord Canning became the 'Viceroy'.
 - **End of Expansion:** Era of annexation ceased; Indian states recognized British paramountcy.
- **Administrative Reorganisation**
 - Military reorganisation emphasised divide and rule, forming units by caste, community, and region. The martial races doctrine prioritised recruitment from loyal groups like Punjabis and Gurkhas.
 - The 1861 Army Amalgamation Scheme transferred Company troops to Crown service, while Indian artillery units were largely disbanded.
 - **Indian Civil Service Act (1861):** It reinforced racial divisions by limiting higher positions to Europeans.
- **White Mutiny: Resentment in the Army:** Company troops resisted allegiance transfer to the Queen due to loss of Batta (extra allowances). British halted socio-cultural reforms, ending the "White Man's Burden" philosophy.

The White Mutiny was a revolt by European soldiers of the East India Company against being transferred to the Queen of England's service. It took place between 1859 and 1861, and was the largest revolt the British army ever faced

Nature of the Revolt of 1857: Historian Viewpoints

- **John Seeley:** Describes it as a "**selfish Sepoy Mutiny**" with no native leadership or popular support.
- **R.C. Mazumdar:** Argues it was "**neither first, national, nor a war of independence**", highlighting its regional and class-based nature.
- **Benjamin Disraeli:** Calls it a "**national revolt rooted in deep mistrust**," acknowledging underlying tensions leading to the uprising.
- **V.D. Savarkar:** Labels it the "**First War of Indian Independence**," considering it a planned and organised effort for freedom.

